

Human Experience

Five Short stories

The Field

I sat in a green field, the grass so lush and soft it felt like a furry blanket laid out just for me. I closed my eyes and felt the warm, delicate kiss of the sun. My God, all this, just for me to experience.

I ran my hands through the grass, and when I opened my eyes, I saw hills rolling into the horizon, dotted with flowers blooming at random. Only me, the sun, and this beautiful earth-blanket of green. Not a single soul or animal. This must be heaven.

If it is, I'll lie here for a moment before wondering how I got here. The air fills my lungs with a freshness that feels like love. In this moment, everything is aligned perfectly. This is peace. This is care. This is... death?

No. Not yet. I don't want to think. I just want to stay here before my mind begins its assault of questions.

But then, a flicker of fear.

What if I am stuck here forever?

Suddenly, heaven starts to feel like hell.

I breathe deeply. In and out.

I open my eyes to the empty blue sky. Not a cloud in sight. Would it be better if someone else were here? Maybe. But people grow tired of each other. So... maybe not. It's an interesting question "interesting" being the word I use to soften the edge of panic.

No. Something easier. Let me think of something easier.

Before I got here, I was just walking through the crowded streets of New York. A place where introverts like me can disappear into the noise. I crave solitude. Perhaps that's why I'm here—a hell made from good intentions.

The Mirror

She stands in front of the mirror, brushing her hair. Over and over. Long strokes. She finds comfort in repetition, like a ritual. She does this every morning.

Today is different, though. Today, she can't remember if this is a memory or a dream.

The room feels familiar the blue walls, the soft hum of the fan, the smell of jasmine. But something is off. She tries to focus, to hold onto something solid, something real.

Was this her childhood room?

Or... is this someone else's memory?

A child's laughter echoes faintly in the background. Her hand slows. She stares into the mirror and doesn't recognize the eyes looking back.

She drops the brush.

The Morgue

Squish. Drip. Squish.

The only sound echoing through the dimly lit hospital morgue, where Dr. Phillips sits hunched over a stainless-steel table, still wearing the scrubs from his hospital shift earlier that day. A single light hangs above him, casting a focused beam onto the open skull of a Jane Doe. His surgical glasses magnify the gray, glistening folds of the brain he's studying.

He pokes gently.

"This brain," he mutters. "Just fat."

He prods again.

"Capable of so much. And yet... we still don't know how to use it fully."

He studies it, holding it in gloved hands.

In my hands, he thinks, I hold someone's thoughts. Their pain. Their memories. Everything they feared and loved. All of it, held in this organ of fat.

Or... maybe not.

Where do we go when the brain stops? Who is we? Who am I?

Am I the thinker? The observer?

How did I end up in this body, in this brain?

He pokes again. Silence. Stillness.

No answers.

Just the squish of a dead brain, and a living man desperate to understand.

The Silent Lie

"I love you," she says, eyes full of hope.

We sit across from each other on our bed, our hands folded together in our laps—hers small and soft, mine large and unsure.

As soon as she says it, I panic.

Seconds pass. Her hopeful eyes begin to dim.

I pause to think. I don't seem to have the vocabulary to describe what it is that I feel. And the longer I stay silent, the more uneasy she becomes.

The silence stretches too long, tension too thick. I know that the world expects an answer. A quick one. And yet, the more I stay silent, the more I feel the weight of it—of this moment, of her waiting, of the way I am expected to feel and answer.

I know that if I don't say these words, I solidify our fate. But I could say nothing. I could say, "I need time," but would that make me weak in her eyes? Selfish, indecisive? No. It would break her. And I can't bear that. I can't bear the thought of her pain.

But what is love? Is it a feeling, or is it a choice?

I used to think back when I was younger that when I said these three words, they would be followed by a feeling that confirmed them to be true. But here I am, in the moment, and it doesn't feel right. Is that a sign? That it's not love?

You often hear that one can love someone, but not be in love. I do love her as

a person. I choose her over every other person. But in this moment, I find it difficult to say, I love you too.

So does that mean I love her but I'm not in love with her?

Something about that narrative doesn't feel right just like these words.

If love is a choice and not a feeling, then maybe I do love her.

She shifts, beginning to pull her hands away, and instinctively I stop her.

"I love you too," I say, despite my feelings.

A lie.

A sin.

How do people do this?

I can't be the only one feeling like this.

Can I?

Have we all quietly given up on the fairytale of love? The idea that when you meet that special person, you'll just know without hesitation?

We've been sold the story of soulmates and magical connections in books and movies. But as we grow older, we begin to realize: some things are just fairytales and dreams.

But love, true love, like we've described in stories... is it just a fantasy? Like magic?

Would you spend your whole life trying to prove magic is real, despite the world telling you it's not? Even when a part of you whispers, maybe it is?

Is it worth the risk to find out?

Because the risk is real: you might spend your whole life looking for true love, and never find it.

Or

You can choose to love someone. And in choosing, maybe you fall in love.

Maybe there are many routes to the same destination.

And like anything in life, you never really know unless you make a decision and live it. But isn't that what everyone else is doing? Hoping, with every choice, that it's the right one?

I don't know.

The only thing I do know right now is this: even though it doesn't feel right, it's a bigger risk to spend my life alone, searching for something I may never find.

So I say it again, this time with more confidence:

"I love you."

She curls into my arms, and we lie back in bed. I stroke her hair as she falls asleep. Gently. Peacefully.

But I stay awake.

Staring at the ceiling.

What if it never feels right because she isn't the one? Or am I just avoiding the inevitable?

Only time will tell.

The Ascent

Last few steps. Heavy breathing. Sweat dripping. Sun scorching.

I take my final painful step and reach the gates of the monastery at the very top of the mountain.

Yes, you heard me correctly, monastery.

This gate marks the end of my old life. And the beginning of something else.

A new life. The life of a monk.